```
convert to a string //
    $string = serialize($myvar);

    echo $string;
    /* prints
    a:4:{i:0;s:5:"hello";i:1;i:42;i:2;a:2:{i:0;i:1;i:1;s:3:"two";}i:3;s:5:"apple";}
    */

    // you can reproduce the original variable
    $newvar = unserialize($string);

    print_r($newvar);
    /* prints
    Array
    (
        [0] => hello
        [1] => 42
        [2] => Array
            (
                [0] => 1
                [1] => two
            )

        [3] => apple
    )
    */
```

This was the native PHP serialization method. However, since JSON has become so popular in recent years, they decided to add support for it in PHP 5.2. Now you can use the json_encode() and json_decode() functions as well:

```
    // a complex array
    $myvar = array(
        'hello',
        42,
```